IELTS Linking Words & Expressions

1. Adding Information

Use these when you want to add another related idea.

Moreover

Meaning: In addition; also
Example: Moreover, technology has made education more accessible.

Furthermore

Meaning: In addition; additionally
Example: Furthermore, public transport can significantly reduce traffic congestion.

In addition

Meaning: Also; as another point
Example: In addition, students can benefit from practical experience.

Additionally

Meaning: Also; as an additional point
Example: Additionally, the programme provides financial support to disadvantaged students.

What is more

Meaning: Used to add another important point
Example: What is more, it creates employment opportunities for local people.

Besides

Meaning: In addition to what has already been mentioned
Example: Besides, living in a large city provides access to better educational facilities.

Not only... but also...

Meaning: Used to connect two related advantages or ideas
Example: The policy will not only reduce pollution but also improve public health.

As well as

Meaning: In addition to
Example: Exercise improves physical health as well as mental well-being.

2. Giving Examples

Use these when you want to support an idea with a specific example.

For example

Example: Many people work remotely. For example, software developers can often work from anywhere.

For instance

Example: Some cities have introduced environmentally friendly initiatives. For instance, several cities have invested heavily in cycling infrastructure.

Such as

Example: Outdoor activities such as hiking and cycling are becoming increasingly popular.

To illustrate

Example: To illustrate this point, many young people now use online platforms to develop professional skills.

A good example of this is...

Example: A good example of this is the growing popularity of online education.

Take... for example

Example: Take public transport for example. It can significantly reduce the number of cars on the road.

3. Giving Reasons

Use these when explaining **why** something happens.

Because

Example: Many people choose public transport because it is relatively affordable.

Since

Example: Since housing is expensive in major cities, many people choose to live outside urban centres.

As

Example: As technology has become more affordable, internet access has expanded rapidly.

Due to

Meaning: Because of a particular reason
Example: Many flights were delayed due to severe weather conditions.

Owing to

Meaning: Because of
Example: Owing to rising costs, some families have reduced their spending.

Because of

Example: Many people work from home because of the flexibility it provides.

The main reason is that...

Example: The main reason is that people are becoming increasingly concerned about their health.

Important Grammar Point

Use **because + subject + verb**:

> The event was cancelled because it was raining.

Use **because of + noun/noun phrase**:

> The event was cancelled because of the heavy rain.

4. Showing Results and Consequences

Use these when explaining what happens **as a result of something**.

Therefore

Example: Public transport is affordable; therefore, it should be made more accessible.

Thus

Example: The company invested heavily in training and thus improved employee performance.

Consequently

Example: More people are relying on private cars; consequently, traffic congestion has increased.

As a result

Example: The government increased taxes, and as a result, consumer spending declined.

As a consequence

Example: Many forests have been destroyed; as a consequence, biodiversity has declined.

For this reason

Example: Public spaces are essential for communities. For this reason, governments should protect them.

This means that...

Example: More people are working remotely. This means that traditional office environments are changing.

5. Showing Contrast

Use these when presenting an opposite or different idea.

However

Example: Living in a city is convenient. However, it can also be stressful.

Nevertheless

Meaning: Despite what has just been said
Example: The journey was exhausting. Nevertheless, it was a memorable experience.

Nonetheless

Meaning: Despite this
Example: The policy has several weaknesses. Nonetheless, it has produced some positive results.

On the other hand

Example: Living alone offers independence. On the other hand, it can sometimes feel isolating.

In contrast

Example: Urban areas are densely populated. In contrast, rural communities tend to be more spacious.

Whereas

Example: Some people prefer working independently, whereas others perform better in teams.

While

Example: While technology offers many benefits, excessive use can create problems.

Although

Example: Although the city is expensive, it offers excellent career opportunities.

Despite this

Example: The job is demanding. Despite this, I find it extremely rewarding.

6. Showing Concession

Use these when you acknowledge an opposing point before presenting your main argument.

Although

Example: Although social media can be distracting, it can also be an effective educational tool.

Even though

Example: Even though the course was demanding, I found it extremely valuable.

Despite

Example: Despite the high cost, many people continue to live in major cities.

In spite of

Example: In spite of the challenges, the project was successfully completed.

Admittedly

Meaning: Accepting that something is true before presenting another point
Example: Admittedly, online learning lacks some of the interaction found in traditional classrooms.

Granted

Meaning: Accepting one point before presenting a contrasting argument
Example: Granted, technology can sometimes be distracting, but its benefits are considerable.

That said

Meaning: Despite what has just been mentioned
Example: The job is demanding. That said, it provides excellent opportunities for professional growth.

Important Grammar Point

Use despite + noun / -ing:

> Despite the difficulties, we completed the project.
>
> Despite facing difficulties, we completed the project.

Use although + subject + verb:

> Although the project was difficult, we completed it.

7. Comparing Ideas

Use these when discussing similarities or differences.

Similarly

Example: Both cities have excellent public transport. Similarly, they offer extensive cultural opportunities.

Likewise

Example: Parents should encourage reading. Likewise, teachers should create opportunities for independent learning.

In the same way

Example: Exercise improves physical health. In the same way, reading can strengthen mental abilities.

Compared with

Example: Compared with rural areas, cities generally offer more employment opportunities.

In comparison

Example: The old system was relatively slow. In comparison, the new system is much more efficient.

By contrast

Example: Private schools often have smaller classes. By contrast, public schools may have larger student populations.

8. Expressing an Opinion

These are especially useful for **IELTS Speaking Part 3 and Writing Task 2**.

In my opinion

Example: In my opinion, schools should focus more on practical skills.

From my perspective

Example: From my perspective, technology has fundamentally changed the way we communicate.

Personally, I believe...

Example: Personally, I believe that young people should be encouraged to travel.

I would argue that...

Example: I would argue that public transport should be prioritised over road expansion.

I firmly believe that...

Example: I firmly believe that education plays a crucial role in social development.

It seems to me that...

Example: It seems to me that people are becoming increasingly dependent on technology.

As far as I am concerned...

Example: As far as I am concerned, experience is just as important as academic qualifications.

9. Presenting an Alternative

Use these when discussing different choices or possibilities.

Alternatively

Example: People can travel by train. Alternatively, they can take a domestic flight.

Instead

Example: Rather than driving, people could use public transport instead.

Otherwise

Example: We need to act quickly; otherwise, the situation could become worse.

Or else

Example: Governments need to invest in infrastructure, or else congestion will continue to increase.

Another option is to...

Example: Another option is to introduce flexible working arrangements.

10. Explaining and Clarifying

Use these when you want to make your meaning clearer.

In other words

Example: The system is inefficient. In other words, it requires significant improvement.

That is to say

Example: The policy is highly restrictive, that is to say, it limits people's choices considerably.

To put it simply

Example: To put it simply, people need affordable and reliable public transport.

What I mean is...

Example: What I mean is that technology should support education rather than replace teachers.

More specifically

Example: The problem affects young people more specifically because they spend more time online.

11. Emphasising an Important Point

Use these to highlight an important idea.

In particular

Example: Technology has changed many aspects of life, particularly communication.

Especially

Example: This is especially important for young people.

Above all

Example: Above all, governments need to ensure that public services are accessible to everyone.

Most importantly

Example: Most importantly, children need a safe and supportive learning environment.

Indeed

Example: The problem is serious. Indeed, it affects millions of people worldwide.

It is worth noting that...

Example: It is worth noting that not everyone has equal access to technology.

A key point is that...

Example: A key point is that economic growth should not come at the expense of the environment.

12. Sequencing Ideas

Use these to organise your answer logically.

Firstly / First of all / To begin with

Example: To begin with, governments need to identify the root causes of the problem.

Secondly

Example: Secondly, greater investment is needed in public infrastructure.

In addition / Furthermore / Moreover

Example: Furthermore, individuals should also be encouraged to contribute to positive change.

Finally / Lastly

Example: Finally, long-term planning is essential for sustainable development.

13. Showing a Sequence or Process

Use these when describing something that happens step by step.

Initially

Example: Initially, I found the new environment quite challenging.

At first

Example: At first, I was nervous about speaking in public.

Then

Example: Then, I gradually became more confident.

After that

Example: After that, I started participating more actively.

Subsequently

Example: Subsequently, I was given greater responsibility.

Eventually

Example: Eventually, I became comfortable with the new environment.

In the end

Example: In the end, the experience had a positive impact on me.

14. Giving a Balanced Argument

These expressions are particularly useful for **IELTS Speaking Part 3 and Writing Task 2**.

On the one hand...

Use this to introduce one side of an argument.

Example: On the one hand, social media allows people to communicate instantly.

On the other hand...

Use this to introduce the contrasting side.

Example: On the other hand, excessive use of social media can negatively affect mental well-being.

That said...

Use this to acknowledge a different perspective.

Example: Online education is highly convenient. That said, some students still prefer face-to-face interaction.

On balance...

Use this when giving your final judgement after considering both sides.

Example: On balance, I believe that the benefits of social media outweigh its disadvantages when it is used responsibly.

All things considered

Example: All things considered, I would prefer to live in a smaller city.

15. Cause → Effect → Solution

This is one of the most useful structures for IELTS answers.

Step 1: Give the cause

This is mainly because...

> This is mainly because many people lack access to reliable public transport.

Step 2: Explain the result

As a result...

> As a result, they become increasingly dependent on private vehicles.

Step 3: Present a solution

Therefore...

> Therefore, governments should invest more heavily in affordable public transportation.

Step 4: Give a specific solution

One possible solution would be to...

> One possible solution would be to expand public transport networks in suburban areas.

16. Concluding an Answer

Use these expressions when bringing your answer to an end.

Overall

Example: Overall, I believe that technology has had a largely positive impact on education.

To sum up

Example: To sum up, both individuals and governments have a role to play.

In conclusion

Example: In conclusion, investment in education can benefit society in the long term.

All things considered

Example: All things considered, I would prefer to live in a smaller city.

On balance

Example: On balance, I believe the advantages outweigh the disadvantages.

Ultimately

Example: Ultimately, the success of any policy depends on how effectively it is implemented.

17. Natural Linking Expressions for IELTS Speaking

In **Speaking**, avoid sounding as if you are reading an essay. These expressions can make your answers sound more natural and spontaneous.

To introduce an idea

Well, I would say that...

> Well, I would say that technology has completely changed the way we communicate.

To be honest,...

> To be honest, I prefer living in a quieter area.

Personally, I think...

Personally, I think young people should have more opportunities to travel.

As far as I can see,...

As far as I can see, social media has both advantages and disadvantages.

To add an idea

Another thing is that...

Another thing is that living in a city provides better career opportunities.

On top of that,...

On top of that, public transport is relatively affordable.

Besides that,...

Besides that, there are plenty of recreational facilities in the area.

To give an example

For example,...

For example, many students now use online platforms to improve their English.

For instance,...

For instance, online courses allow people to study at their own pace.

A good example would be...

A good example would be my university, which provides students with numerous extracurricular activities.

To contrast

Having said that,...

Having said that, technology can sometimes be distracting.

That said,...

That said, I still believe that its benefits outweigh its disadvantages.

At the same time,...

> At the same time, people need to use technology responsibly.

To conclude

So, overall,...

> So, overall, I think technology has had a positive impact on our lives.

All in all,...

> All in all, it was a highly rewarding experience.

Ultimately,...

> Ultimately, I think people should choose a lifestyle that suits their individual circumstances.

18. High-Value Linking Structures for Band 9

Rather than memorising individual linking words, learn how to connect them naturally.

Opinion → Reason → Example

> **In my opinion**, public transport should be improved **because** it can reduce traffic congestion. **For example**, efficient metro systems can transport thousands of people every day.

Point → Contrast → Opinion

> **On the one hand**, social media makes communication easier. **On the other hand**, it can be highly distracting. **Overall**, I think its impact depends largely on how responsibly people use it.

Cause → Result → Solution

> Many people rely on private cars **because** public transport is unreliable. **As a result**, traffic congestion has increased. **Therefore**, governments should invest in more efficient transport networks.

Main Idea → Example → Result

> Technology has transformed education. **For instance**, students can now access online courses from almost anywhere. **As a result**, learning has become considerably more flexible.

Band 9 Reminder

Do not try to use a linking word in every sentence.

Natural:

> I enjoy living in a city **because** there are plenty of opportunities. **For example**, I can easily find educational and professional events. **However**, the cost of living can be quite high.

Overused:

> **Moreover**, I enjoy living in a city. **Furthermore**, there are many opportunities. **Nevertheless**, there are disadvantages. **Consequently**, I think...

The second version can sound **memorised and unnatural**.

Remember:

Clear idea + Appropriate linker + Natural sentence + Relevant example

The purpose of linking words is to make your ideas **flow logically**, not simply to make your vocabulary sound complicated.